The Impact of Narrative Pedagogy on Student Learning

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Abstract

Narrative pedagogy is one teaching method that designs curriculum using the tenets of story and narrative to shape understanding of self and others. This approach seeks to challenge dominant narratives and cultivate reflective thinking. This study explores how narrative pedagogy, within a diverse First Year Experience course, impacts student learning and development at a large PWI institution. Students engaged in a series of assignments using text, film, and personal narratives, that culminate in the production of an original documentary short film. Films focused on one of three issues: the American dream, home and place, and critical moments in the Twin Cities. Preliminary results suggest engaging in this approach positively impacts students' learning outcomes in the following areas: interpersonal and intrapersonal competence, humanitarianism and civic engagement, and cognitive complexity.

Study Design

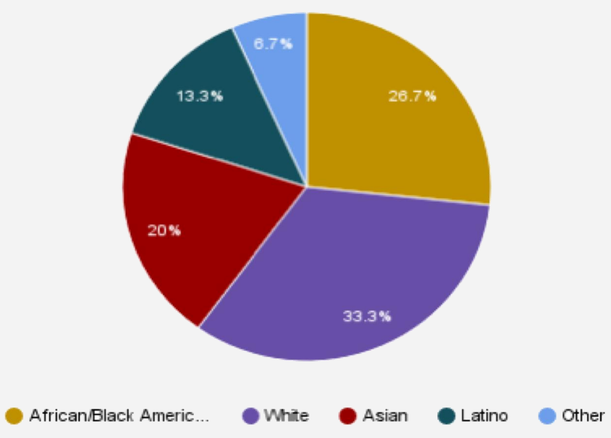
This is part of a larger study that includes two cohorts of student participants from Fall 2013 and 2014. Data includes reflective writings that students complete at four points during the semester (wk. 4, wk. 8, wk. 12 and wk. 13). Preliminary analysis focused on two arenas that emerged from the data set:

- **processes** that students named as central to the development and completion of the documentary film.
- **learning outcomes** that reflect cognitive, intrapersonal, and interpersonal development that emerged from participation in documentary production.

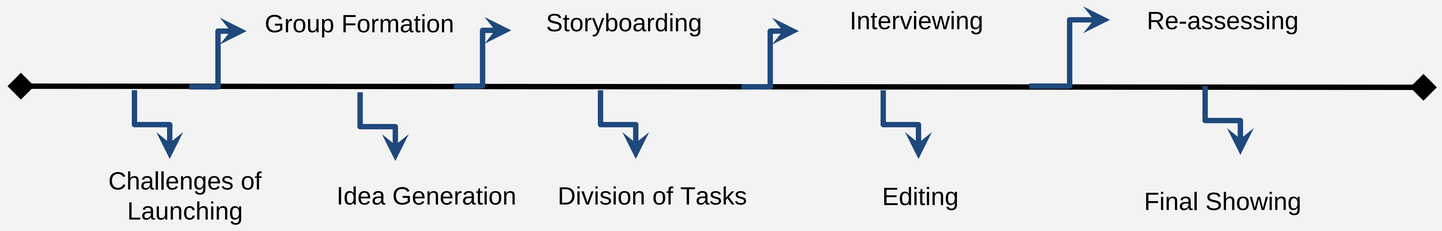
Participants and Data Analysis

Subjects in the 2014 cohort include 63 students. 46.8% are students of color and 53.2% are White. For this particular portion of the analysis, we used data from a representative sample of 15 subjects. Qualitative analysis and constructive analysis included two phases: process outcomes and learning outcomes. Analysis for process outcomes began with three participants to determine emergent themes. The research team then cross-checked these categories with the other participant texts until there was a saturation of categories. The second phase included coding data for learning outcomes using pre-determined codes from the Council for the Advancement of Standards in Higher Education (CAS), a consortium that promotes intra-campus collaboration and reflects good practices agreed upon by the profession-at-large.

Participant Breakdown (Subset)



Findings: Process Outcomes



Findings: Learning Outcomes

Interpersonal Competence

Meaningful Relationships, Interdependence, Collaboration, & Effective Leadership

"Throughout this project, I have learned to listen and be more patient with others. There were times where we were not able to compromise, but I understood that it was for the best of the group. We each had learned things about each other that we wouldn't have known if not for this project."

Basra, Black Female.

Intrapersonal Development

Realistic Self-Appraisal and self understanding & Identity Development

"I also had to learn to let others in the group take control over some aspects of the project. While it was easy for me to feel that I had to do everything in order to make sure it got done correctly, I learned that other members of my group were better equipped to deal with certain aspects of the project, and therefore, should take the lead on the particular section of the assignment."

Abigail, White Female.

Humanitarianism and Civic Engagement

Appreciation of cultural and human differences, Global Perspective & Social Responsibility

"I also learned to accept opinions of other people more readily. For example, there are ways that I do things that are different than what the group did but, it's about getting over your own ways and taking into consideration what others want and which will work better. Overall, I think this was an excellent and very introspective project and I'm proud of how it turned out."

Blake, Latino Male.

Cognitive Complexity

Constructing knowledge, Relating knowledge to daily life, Reflective Thinking & Critical Thinking

"We did not just have one perspective on adoption, we had a parent, and adoptee and a biological son. This helped the audiences …have the ability to see three different lenses on the outlook of adoption and specifically helped me become more open-minded because that enabled me to have a changed outlook on adoption. After making the documentary about adoption and seeing a different definitions of family… it opened up my eyes in many ways about the world that surrounds me. This documentary helped me change my definition of family, it expanded the criteria for family."

Vanessa, Asian Female.

Discussion

Studies like these can inform ways in which pedagogy influences student learning, particularly in diverse classroom spaces. As the demography in the United States continues to diversify, classrooms must evolve with it, in order to better prepare students for active participation as global citizens. The key learning outcomes above, suggest that in working to create an original film, students engaged in many *narrative encounters.* This allowed for deeper reflection of self and others, as well as construction and application of new learning to global contexts. The intersection of the outcomes above is intentional, as preliminary analysis suggests that some outcomes inform each other. For e.g., effective interpersonal engagement often resulted in self-reflection and intrapersonal development and vice versa.

Council for the Advancement of Standards in Higher Education (2009). CAS learning and development outcomes. In L. A. Dean (Ed.), *CAS professional standards for higher education* (7th ed.). Washington, DC: Author.